

- RAG Learning

2.2 Children's Written Language Development

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 2 Child Language

Writing is a **culturally learned** system — unlike speech it requires motor skill, orthographic knowledge, genre awareness and audience positioning. Key frameworks: **Kroll's** stages, **Britton's** functions, **Rothery's** genres, **Gentry's** spelling stages, and **Halliday's** metafunctions applied to text production.

2.2.1 Emergent Writing

Before children can form letters, they produce mark-making — scribbles, shapes, letter-like forms. This shows awareness that writing uses discrete symbols arranged in lines, directionality, word spacing, and a difference between drawing and writing.

2.2.2 Kroll's Four Stages (1981)

Kroll's Four Stages of Writing Development



Preparation (up to ~6)

Motor control develops for letter formation. Child learns letter-sound links, begins phonetic spelling, writes simple high-frequency words.

Consolidation (7–8)

Writing resembles speech. Coordination with "and", "then"; simple past; first person; limited punctuation; expressive voice dominates.

Differentiation (9–10)

Child distinguishes spoken and written styles. More varied sentence types, subordination with "because", "although". More formal register for appropriate genres.

Integration (teenage onwards)

Flexible control of a range of styles adapted to audience, purpose and genre. Varied sentence openings, non-finite clauses, complex noun phrases, modality, evaluation, paragraphing, skilled graphology.

2.2.3 Britton's Three Functions (1970)

Function	Description	Examples
Expressive	Speech on paper — personal voice, unedited	Diaries, letters to friends
Transactional	Gets something done in the world	Letters to institutions, reports, essays
Poetic	Crafted — attentive to form, sound, pattern	Poems, stories, stylised narrative

Early writing is predominantly expressive and gradually develops into transactional and poetic forms through schooling.

2.2.4 Rothery's Four Genres

Genre	Structure	Example
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Recount	Orientation → events chronologically → optional reorientation	"At the weekend I went to..."
Report	General statement → aspects → concluding comment	"Penguins are birds..."
Narrative	Orientation → complication → resolution	"One day the boy saw a dragon..."
Observation / comment	Identification of event + evaluative remark	"We saw a robin. It was pretty."

The Sydney School argued explicit genre teaching is a matter of **equity**: children from literacy-rich homes enter school already familiar with these structures.

2.2.5 Gentry's Spelling Stages

Stage	Feature	Example
Pre-communicative	Letters without sound-letter mapping	"PLKMS" for "dog"
Semi-phonetic	Some sound-letter links (mostly consonants)	"DG" for "dog"
Phonetic	Systematic sound-by-sound spelling	"cum" for "come"
Transitional	Orthographic patterns overgeneralised	"beleve"
Conventional	Consistent standard spelling	Mature orthography

Spelling errors are linguistic evidence — "phonetic" mis-spellings show sound-letter mapping internalised.

2.2.6 Grammar, Punctuation and Cohesion

Early writers typically:

- Rely on **coordination** ("and", "then", "so").
- Omit or inconsistently use **full stops**.
- Lack **paragraphing** and broader cohesion.
- Use simple past throughout narratives.
- Include first-person perspective typical of speech.

Development introduces: subordination, non-finite clauses, complex noun phrases, cohesive devices beyond "then", modality and evaluation.

2.2.7 Interaction with Spoken Development

Writing builds on speech but is not reducible to it. Early writing often shows spoken features (coordination, first-person, run-on structure). As children advance they learn to:

- Depersonalise — third-person reports, passive constructions.
- Plan and edit — revisit and improve.
- Address a distant reader — compensating for absent shared context.
- Use written-only conventions — punctuation, paragraphing, headings.

2.2.8 Scaffolding Writing Pedagogy

Drawing on Vygotsky (ZPD) and Bruner (scaffolding):

1. **Modelled writing** — teacher composes aloud.
2. **Shared writing** — class suggests, teacher drafts.
3. **Guided writing** — small-group support.
4. **Independent writing** — with success criteria.

Genre-based pedagogy adds the **teaching and learning cycle**: deconstruction → joint construction → independent construction.

2.2.9 Digital Writing

Research (Crystal, Tagg, Wood) suggests children switch between digital and standard registers — adding registers rather than replacing standard writing. Texters with better phonological awareness tend to produce more creative abbreviations.

Applied Example: A Year 6 narrative opening: "*Darkness fell across the city, silent but for a single, flickering streetlight. Mia had been waiting.*" Features: post-modifying adjective phrase ("silent but for..."), complex noun phrase, past perfect progressive, short simple sentence. Across frameworks: Kroll — integration stage; Britton — poetic function dominant; Rothery — narrative genre; Halliday — textual metafunction strong. Top-band answers name feature, framework, stage and reader effect.

2.2.10 How to Analyse a Child's Writing

1. Identify **audience, purpose, genre**.
2. Place on **Kroll's stages** with evidence.
3. Identify dominant **Britton function**.
4. Map the **Rothery genre structure**.
5. Analyse at linguistic levels — *lexis, grammar, graphology, cohesion*.
6. Discuss **errors as evidence** (spelling stage, virtuous errors).
7. Integrate a **theoretical frame** — Vygotsky's ZPD for teaching implications, Halliday for metafunctions.

Exam Tip: Always link features to development. "Coordination with 'and' appears repeatedly — typical of Kroll's consolidation stage, where writing follows speech patterns. A target is varied subordination, which would move the writer towards differentiation." That sentence integrates feature, framework, stage and pedagogy.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define and exemplify: **emergent writing, mark-making, Kroll's four stages, Britton's three functions, Rothery's four genres, Gentry's spelling stages, orthography, coordination vs subordination, cohesion, non-finite clause, modality, scaffolding, ZPD, teaching & learning cycle.**